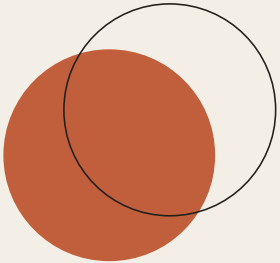
November 6, 2026

# Research with AI Agents

*What Works, What It Costs, and What an Institute Needs*

Lukas Theissinger



# Outline

I. OpenAI and Agent Usage

II. Owning Intelligence and Infrastructure at Lamarr

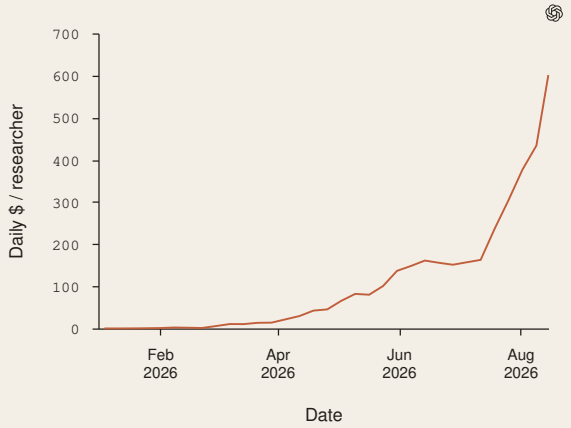


OUTLINE

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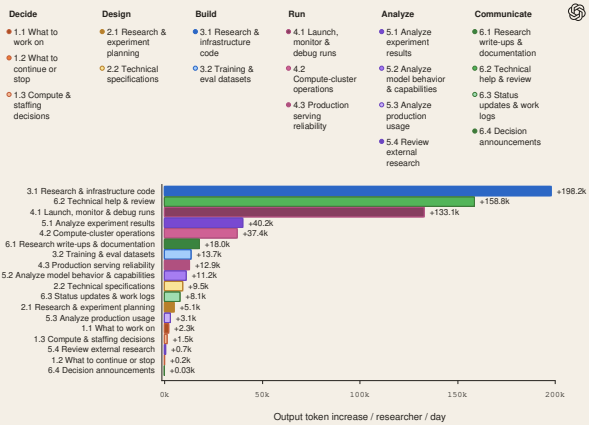
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# FOMO Headline: OpenAI Agent Usage



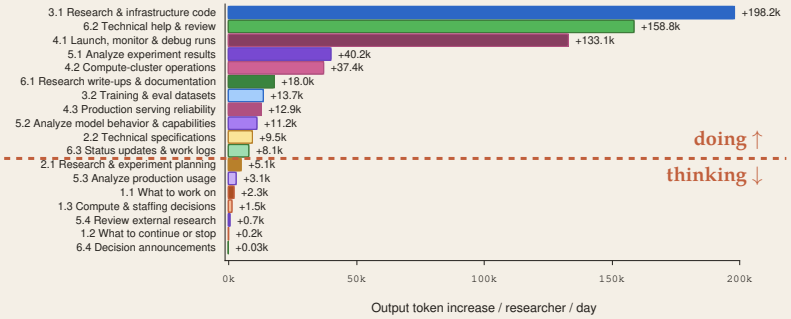

Median researcher, daily $ spent on internal coding agents. Source: OpenAI, "Research acceleration" (self-reported)

# What do agents do at OpenAI?




Increase in output tokens per researcher per day, by research activity. Source: OpenAI, "Research acceleration" (self-reported)

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| Did agents take over the *thinking*? We can't say: a plan or a decision is short, so tokens are the wrong measure | Agent use is a *skill*: not everything can or should be automated (degree of automation) |

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# Field Report: Automating Exercises

1. **The problem.** PhD student, tutoring an exercise class every two weeks:
   - 2 h exercise class + 6 h preparation (solving the tasks, making the slides)
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4. **Ask your agent to try it:** `github.com/Newida/AutomatingExercises` **Avoid:** Don't do anything BY HAND on this project. If you want to change it, ASK YOUR AGENT to change it

# II

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Example: travel expense reports

Collect receipts, fill in the university form, look up per-diem rules, fix what admin sends back: say **3 trips** × **3 h per person per year**. An agent that reads the receipts and files the form correctly needs ∼**200 h** (rules, forms, access to the admin system)

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| institute, 10 000 people | $10\,000 \times 9\,\text{h} = 90\,000\,\text{h/year}$ | 200 h | **pays >400×** |

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So let's talk about costs

# Decision 1: Subscription or API?

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- \+ very cheap for heavy interactive use
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Our comparison: one month of my usage, priced at API list prices

| | subscription | same usage via API | factor |
|---|---|---|---|
| Claude | 20 $ (Pro) | ∼680 $ | ∼34× |
| Codex | 20 $ (Plus) | ∼145 $ | ∼7× |

But one batch job, 27 benchmark tasks via API, cost only **2.25 $**

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QUALITY: OUR QUANTUM-CODING BENCHMARK (27 TASKS, SOLVED), SO FAR ONLY SMALL OPEN MODELS

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| Qwen, self-hosted on one GPU | 10/27 |
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Small open models are clearly behind. The largest open models are much closer to the frontier; on our tasks they are **still untested**

# Self-Hosting for the Institute: Pros and Cons

**Quality and performance**

+ data never leaves Lamarr (privacy, unpublished work, GDPR)
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ROUGH COMPARISON

2 nodes × 300 k€ over 4 years ≈ 12.5 k€/month ≈ **300 people** × **40 €** ≈ **125 people** × **100 €**

With Lamarr's compute, a frontier-class open model for everyone is realistic: it pays off through privacy, scale and no caps; the closed models keep a lead of months

# Field Report: Self-Hosting in Practice

**Main model: GLM-5.3-Flash, 45 days**

| | 45 days | per month |
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| input tokens | 28.3 B | ∼19 B |
| of it cached | 25.4 B (90 %) | |
| output tokens | 585 M | ∼390 M |
| at Z.ai prices | $4.5 k | ∼$3 k |
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| energy (full load) | 500–1000 € | ∼330–670 € |
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**Takeaway**

Running the model is cheap (energy ≪ API bill). The real costs are the hardware [?] and the expert who keeps it running

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## For the institute

1. **Automate workflows for every individual:** what never pays off for one person pays off for 10 000

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1. **Automate workflows for every individual:** what never pays off for one person pays off for 10 000
2. **Provide your employees with agents**

# Takeaways

## For the individual

1. **You need to use AI agents**
2. **Use AI agents to change your bottlenecks at work**
3. **Automate, to a degree, only what pays off:**
   how often × time saved > time to build
4. **Use AI to build your own AI setup**
   Learn by doing, tailor it to your workflow, and make your daily work easier

## For the institute

1. **Automate workflows for every individual:** what never pays off for one person pays off for 10 000
2. **Provide your employees with agents**
3. **Consider self-hosting**

# Next: David's Setup

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2. David shows **his own setup**: how it looks in daily work for him

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1. We know that we **need AI agents** and what to use them for
2. David shows **his own setup**: how it looks in daily work for him
3. The best setup is **personal and custom**, so build your own